

THE MUSIC PRODUCER'S COMPLETE GENRE GUIDE

How to Create Music Across Genres — From First Sound to Finished Track
Extreme Detail • Production Blueprints • Mixing Notes • Arrangement Maps

Written for producers, beatmakers, songwriters, and engineers
who want practical, genre-accurate workflows

Covers Hip-Hop, Trap, Drill, Boom Bap • House, Techno, Trance, DnB,
Dubstep

Pop, R&B, Soul • Rock, Metal, Punk • Jazz, Funk, Disco • Latin, Afrobeats,
Reggae

Ambient, Lo-fi, Synthwave, Hyperpop, Country, Gospel, Classical Crossover &
more

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PART I — Foundations Every Producer Needs

1. The Producer Mindset & Workflow

A music producer is not only someone who “makes beats.” In professional terms, the producer is responsible for the overall sonic identity, arrangement decisions, performance direction, and the emotional arc of a record. In bedroom and DAW-native workflows, you often wear producer, songwriter, engineer, and mixer hats at once. Genre literacy is what lets you choose the right decisions under pressure — not rigid rules, but recognizable contracts with the listener’s ear.

Every genre answers a different set of questions for the audience: How hard should the low end hit? How much space should drums leave for vocals? Is the groove behind, on, or ahead of the beat? Is harmony dense or sparse? Is the mix polished and competitive, or intentionally raw? When you understand those contracts, you can either fulfill them cleanly or break them deliberately (which is how new micro-genres form).

A reliable start-to-finish workflow

- **Reference first:** Import 2–4 commercial tracks in the target genre. Match rough loudness, study drum density, vocal placement, and sidechain behavior.
- **Tempo & grid:** Set BPM and decide swing/groove template before writing. Wrong grid = wrong feel forever.
- **Core loop:** Build a 4–8 bar idea that already feels like the genre (drums + bass + one harmonic/melodic hook).
- **Expand arrangement:** Map intro / verse / pre / chorus / bridge / outro (or dance form: intro–build–drop–break).
- **Sound design pass:** Replace placeholders with final-quality samples/synths. Layer intentionally.
- **Vocal / lead focus:** If there is a vocal, everything else serves it. Carve mix space early.
- **Mix in context:** Balance, EQ, compression, spatial effects, automation while arrangement is still flexible.
- **Print & rest:** Export, walk away, then revise with fresh ears against references.

***Producer tip:** Finish more tracks than you perfect. Genre fluency comes from completing 20 average songs in a style, not one endlessly tweaked loop.*

2. Core Music Theory for Production

You do not need conservatory training to produce commercially, but you do need practical theory: keys, scales, intervals, chords, voice leading, and how rhythm interacts with harmony. Theory is a map of options — it speeds up decisions and helps you communicate with musicians.

Keys, modes, and genre tendencies

Minor keys dominate modern hip-hop, trap, drill, metal, and much electronic music because they read as serious, dark, or emotional. Major keys still own large parts of pop, country, gospel, and uplifting dance. Modes matter: Dorian (minor with raised 6th) feels groovy/soulful; Phrygian (flat 2) feels Spanish/metal/dark electronic; Mixolydian (major with flat 7) feels bluesy/rock; Lydian (raised 4) feels dreamy/cinematic. Aeolian (natural minor) is the default “sad/modern” palette. Harmonic minor (raised 7th) creates tension used in metal, classical, and some EDM.

Chord vocabulary that actually gets used

- **Triads:** major, minor, diminished, augmented — foundation of almost everything.
- **7ths:** maj7, m7, dominant 7 — essential for R&B, jazz, neo-soul, lo-fi, gospel.
- **Extensions:** 9, 11, 13 — add color without changing function; stack carefully to avoid mud.
- **Sus2 / sus4:** open, modern, pop/ambient friendly.
- **Power chords (root + 5th):** rock/metal guitars; leave third out for distortion clarity.
- **Parallel minor/major moves:** common emotional “lift” or “drop” in pop choruses.

- **Modal interchange:** borrow bVI, bVII, iv from parallel minor into major progressions (very pop/rock).

Voice leading & bass motion

Listeners hear bass motion and top-line melody more clearly than inner chord notes. Strong bass lines often move by step or by fifths. Keep common tones when changing chords; move other voices the shortest distance. In electronic genres, the “bass” may be a mono synth following root notes with slides (portamento) rather than walking jazz lines — both are valid, genre-dependent choices.

Rhythm theory producers actually use

Meter is usually 4/4 in commercial music; 3/4 and 6/8 appear in ballads, waltzes, and some folk/country; odd meters (5/4, 7/8) appear in progressive and experimental work. Subdivision (8ths, 16ths, triplets) defines genre feel as much as tempo. Swing ratios (straight vs swung 16ths) separate house from boom bap from jazz. Syncopation — accents off the strong beats — is the soul of funk, Latin, Afrobeats, and modern R&B.

3. Sound Design Basics (Synths, Samples, FX)

Sound design is choosing and shaping timbre so that the arrangement reads as a coherent world. Genres have timbral signatures: 808s and dark pads for trap; supersaws for trance; Rhodes and vinyl crackle for lo-fi; tight acoustic kits for jazz; distorted guitars for metal. Learn subtractive synthesis first (oscillators → filter → amp envelopes → modulation), then FM, wavetable, granular, and sampling.

The signal chain mental model

- **Source:** oscillator, sample, recording, noise generator.
- **Tone shape:** filter (LP/HP/BP/notch), waveshaping, distortion, bitcrush.
- **Dynamics shape:** ADSR envelopes on amp and filter; compression later in mix.
- **Motion:** LFOs, step sequencers, macros, automation.
- **Space:** delay, reverb, chorus, phaser, stereo width tools.
- **Glue:** bus compression, saturation, clipping for loudness and character.

Sampling ethics & technique

Classic hip-hop and many electronic styles are sample-based. Legally, commercial releases usually require clearance or use royalty-free / original material. Creatively: chop to transient, pitch to key, time-stretch with algorithms that preserve (or intentionally destroy) transients, layer with one-shots, and process heavily so the sample becomes a new instrument. Resampling your own synths is a pro habit — print audio, then treat it as a sample for further mangling.

4. Drums, Groove & Rhythm Foundations

If harmony is the body of a track, drums are the heartbeat. Genre is often recognized in the first bar by kick pattern, snare/clap placement, hi-hat density, and percussion vocabulary.

The four drum pillars

- **Kick:** weight, length, click (beater/transient), mono low end. Tune kick to key when possible.
- **Snare/clap:** backbeat identity. Layer body + snap + room/verb tail. Ghost notes add human feel.
- **Hats/cymbals:** timekeeper and energy. Open hat on offbeats is classic house; 1/32 rolls are trap.
- **Percussion:** shakers, congas, rims, snaps, foley — they create culture-specific identity.

Humanization without chaos

Quantize to a groove template rather than hard 100% grid for swing genres. Vary velocities (especially hats). Nudge selected hits 5–15 ms early/late for push/pull. Use slightly different samples on repeats (round-robin).

Over-humanizing electronic genres can destroy the hypnotic machine feel — know when tightness is the aesthetic.

5. Arrangement Architecture

Arrangement is storytelling with energy. Song-based genres (pop, rock, R&B, country) usually follow verse–pre–chorus–chorus structures with a bridge. Dance genres use DJ-friendly structures with long intros for mixing, tension builds, and drops. Hip-hop often loops with section changes marked by vocal density, ad-libs, and instrumental drops rather than huge harmonic shifts.

Energy tools (any genre)

- Add/remove layers (filter open = energy up; filter closed = energy down).
- Change drum density (half-time vs double-time feels).
- Rise/fall FX, reverse cymbals, white noise sweeps, impact hits.
- Silence / dropouts (1 bar of near-silence before a drop is classic).
- Vocal chops as transitions; risers into choruses.
- Key lift (modulation up a semitone/whole tone) for final chorus — use sparingly.
- Breakdown: strip to pads/vocals, then rebuild.

6. Mixing & Mastering Essentials by Genre Context

Mixing goals change by genre. Pop/R&B wants vocal intelligibility and polish. Techno wants club translation and mono-compatible low end. Metal wants guitar clarity and drum impact without fizz. Lo-fi may intentionally limit bandwidth and add noise. Always mix on multiple systems (monitors, headphones, phone, car) and check mono.

Universal mix order of operations

- Gain staging: peaks healthy, headroom for processing (–6 to –12 dBFS peaks early).
- High-pass non-bass elements carefully; leave room for kick/bass relationship.
- Balance faders first — if it doesn't work at static balance, plugins won't save it.
- EQ subtractively to fix; additively for character.
- Compression for control and groove (bus glue vs peak control vs parallel punch).
- Spatial effects last in creative chain; filter delays/verbs so they don't muddy lows.
- Automation is mix magic: rides on vocals, filter moves, send levels by section.
- Mastering: gentle EQ, multiband control if needed, limiter for competitive loudness. Leave true peak headroom (~–1 dBTP streaming).

Producer tip: The kick–bass relationship is the #1 genre-defining mix problem. Solve it with complementary EQ, sidechain, or frequency splitting (kick owns sub on hits; bass fills between) before adding more low-end layers.

PART II — Urban & Black American Traditions

These genres share deep rhythmic innovation, sampling culture, vocal-forward storytelling, and low-end emphasis. They dominate global charts and streaming, and their production vocabulary (808s, half-time feel, ad-libs, melodic loops) has infected nearly every other popular style.

7. Boom Bap & Classic Hip-Hop

The head-nod foundation of golden-era hip-hop production

Typical BPM	85–98 (sweet spot ~90–94)
Feel	Swung or lightly swung 16ths; hard kick/snare “boom–bap”
Keys	Minor common; samples often dictate key/mode
Core elements	Sampled drums or SP-style kits, chopped loops, bass, scratches, raw vocals
Mix vibe	Mid-forward, punchy drums, not ultra-loud modern streaming smash

Historical DNA

Boom bap (named for kick “boom” and snare “bap”) crystallized in late-80s/90s New York — Think DJ Premier, Pete Rock, Large Professor, RZA, Q-Tip as producers who defined the vocabulary. The aesthetic values crate-digging, imperfect loops, dusty texture, and drums that feel like they hit your chest without modern 808 sub dominance.

Drum programming

Kick & snare

- Kick on 1 and often the “and” of 2 or other syncopations; not always four-on-the-floor.
- Snare on 2 and 4 with authority — this is the “bap.” Layer a tight snare + roomy snare for body.
- Ghost snares and rimshots between hits create pocket (especially Premier-style).

Hats & percussion

- Closed hats in 8ths or swung 16ths; occasional open hat.
- Perc: bongos, shakers, vinyl noise, chopped break fragments.

Classic approach

- Start from breakbeats (Amen, Funky Drummer–style vocabulary historically) or recreate with one-shots.
- Use MPC-style timing: slight swing, velocity variation, sometimes non-quantized chops.

Sampling & harmony

Chop soul, jazz, funk records into 1–4 bar loops or micro-chops rearranged into new progressions. Pitch samples to a key; filter mud; add saturation. Common harmony: minor 7 loops, ii–V suggestions, modal vamps. Bass can be sampled electric bass or a simple sine/triangle following roots. Leave space for vocals — boom bap mixes are often less dense than modern trap.

Arrangement

- Intro: filtered loop or scratch phrase.
- Verse: full drums + loop; occasional dropouts for punchlines.
- Hook: add chorus vocals, counter-melody, or horn stab; sometimes switch chop.
- Bridge/breakdown: drums drop or switch to different sample.
- Outro: scratches, fade, or beat stop.

Producer tip: Print your sample through tape/console emulation, then re-chop. Character compounds.

Mixing notes

- Drums slightly louder than modern pop relative to music bed.
- High-pass samples around 100–200 Hz if bass is separate; or let sample carry lows carefully.
- Parallel compression on drums for punch.
- Vocal: presence 2–5 kHz, de-ess, short plate or room; keep intelligible over dusty beds.
- Avoid over-limiting; preserve transient snap of the snare.

8. Trap & Modern Hip-Hop

808s, hi-hat sewing machines, dark melodies, streaming-era low end

Typical BPM	130–160 with half-time feel (feels like 65–80) OR 70–90 straight
Feel	Half-time snare on 3; rapid hat rolls; sliding 808s
Keys	Minor (natural, harmonic, Phrygian); dark modes
Core elements	808 bass, crisp snare/clap, hi-hat rolls, dark bells/pads/leads, ad-libs
Mix vibe	Loud, sub-heavy, vocal-forward, wide tops, mono lows

What “trap” means for producers

Trap evolved from Southern hip-hop (Atlanta lineage especially) into a global production language. Even non-rap genres now borrow trap drums. The signature is the relationship between a long, tuned 808 bass drum and intricate hi-hat programming, usually with a snare/clap emphasizing beat 3 in a half-time grid at higher BPMs.

Drum blueprint

Grid & snare

- Set 140 BPM as a common starting point. Place snare/clap on beat 3 of each bar (half-time).
- Layer clap + snare + maybe a transient click. Short reverb (0.6–1.2s) with high-pass on the verb.

Hi-hats

- 1/8 and 1/16 patterns as base; add 1/32 and 1/64 rolls into downbeats.
- Pitch automation on rolls (rising or falling) is a genre cliché that still works when musical.
- Velocity: not flat — humanize lightly or program accents.
- Open hats and rides for section lift.

Kick vs 808

- Often the 808 IS the kick (long sine with punch). Sometimes a short kick layers on top of 808 hits.
- Program 808 pattern as a bassline: roots, fifths, chromatic slides, dead notes (short muted hits).
- Portamento/glide on monophonic 808 is essential for modern trap melodies in the bass.

Melody & sound design

- Dark plucks, bells, Rhodes, distorted pianos, flute/voice-like leads, minor key arps.
- Keep motifs simple and loopable; hip-hop thrives on hypnotic repetition with variation.
- Scale choices: natural minor, harmonic minor for Middle-Eastern spice, Phrygian for menace.
- Counter-melodies enter in hooks; verses may be sparser.
- Atmos: reverse FX, distant choirs, risers, vinyl optional (less than lo-fi).

Arrangement map (typical song)

- 0:00 Intro (melodic motif + FX, drums enter partially)
- 0:15 Verse 1 (full drums, vocal main)
- 0:45 Pre/Hook setup (hat energy up, riser)

- 1:00 Chorus/Hook (fullest layers, ad-libs)
- 1:30 Verse 2 (variation: new 808 line or melody layer)
- 2:00 Hook 2
- 2:30 Bridge/breakdown or beat switch
- 3:00 Final hook + outro

Producer tip: Program the 808 and vocal melody to leave pocket for each other — if both fight mid-low, cut 200–400 Hz on one.

Mixing trap specifically

- 808: mono below ~120 Hz; saturation for small-speaker audibility; multiband or dynamic EQ vs kick click.
- Sidechain hats/pads lightly to 808 if needed; classic is ducking pads/music to kick/808.
- Vocal chain: tuning (subtle or hard), de-ess, compression (serial), presence EQ, delay throws, short verb, autopan ad-libs.
- Stereo: keep sub mono; widen bells/pads/FX; check phase.
- Loudness: competitive but leave headroom for streaming codecs; true peak limit.

9. Drill (UK & US)

Sliding 808s, menacing patterns, street narrative energy

Typical BPM	UK: ~138–146 US Chicago-rooted: ~60–70 half-time feel / ~130–145
Feel	Stuttering hats, sharp snares, sliding 808 basslines, dark minor melodies
Keys	Minor, often very dark; sparse harmony
Core elements	808 slides, cold piano/lead, aggressive vocal delivery, drill snare patterns
Mix vibe	Hard-hitting, cold, vocal center, ominous space

UK vs US distinctions

Chicago drill (Chief Keef era influence) emphasized bleak melodies and a distinctive drum bounce. UK drill evolved with different rhythmic cadences, more complex 808 slides, and a colder sonic palette that influenced global drill (NY drill, etc.). As a producer, study regional drum patterns and vocal flows separately — the 808 writing is a major differentiator.

Production focus

- 808s with long glides between notes; chromatic approach notes; silence as part of the pattern.
- Snares often sharper and more syncopated than generic trap.
- Melodies: minor piano loops, tense strings, desaturated bells — avoid happy major progressions.
- Leave rhythmic space for aggressive vocal syncopation.
- Sound selection is colder: less “musical theater,” more “street night air.”

Producer tip: Write the 808 after a rough vocal rhythm sketch when possible — drill 808s converse with flow.

10. R&B / Contemporary R&B

Groove, harmony color, vocal intimacy, sensual low end

Typical BPM	60–90 ballad/groove 90–115 midtempo some uptempo 115–130
Feel	Swung or deeply pocketed; ghost notes; syncopated bass
Keys	Rich harmony: 7ths, 9ths, 11ths; major & minor; modal interchange
Core elements	Electric bass or 808 hybrid, keys (Rhodes/piano), guitars, airy drums, stacked vocals
Mix vibe	Vocal throne, warm mids, smooth top, controlled sub

Harmonic language

Contemporary R&B lives in extended chords. Learn progressions using maj7, m9, dom9, half-diminished, and slash chords. Voice lead smoothly. Neo-soul (D’Angelo, Erykah Badu lineage) pushes jazz harmony further; mainstream R&B may simplify for hooks but still colors verses. Borrow chords from parallel modes freely. Use secondary dominants to approach the iv or V with tension.

Drum & groove

- Kick patterns syncopate around the vocal; not always simple 1-and-3.
- Snare/clap can be layered softly; rimshots and snaps for verses.
- Hats: swung 16ths, shakers layered, sparse opens.
- Program ghost kicks and ghost snares for pocket.
- Live-feeling kits or crisp modern one-shots both work depending on substyle (throwback vs dark R&B).

Bass

Electric bass (DI + amp sim) with slides, dead notes, and syncopation is classic. Modern R&B often blends 808 sub under melodic bass. Sidechain gently to kick. Follow chord tones: roots, fifths, approach chromatics, occasional thirds for sweetness.

Vocals & arrangement

- Lead intimate and dry-ish in verses; wetter wider choruses.
- Stacks: thirds/fifths harmonies, octaves, whispered doubles, ad-lib answers.
- Pre-chorus lifts via rising chords, drum fills, or filter opens.
- Breakdowns with pads and voice are emotional peaks.

Producer tip: Automate a “closer mic” feel in verses (less reverb, more proximity/bass on vocal) and open the space in choruses.

Sound palette

Rhodes, Wurlitzer, soft acoustic piano, clean/chorus guitars, atmospheric pads, vinyl optional, subtle tape wow. Avoid harsh supersaws unless doing hybrid pop-R&B. Distortion is satin, not metal.

11. Soul, Neo-Soul & Gospel

Human feel, choir power, organ/piano truth, emotional dynamics

Typical BPM	70–100 soul/gospel ballads to midgroove; uptempo gospel can push higher
Feel	Behind-the-beat pocket; swing; dynamic human performance
Keys	Gospel: rich progressions, secondary dominants, “shout” sections; soul: classic I–IV–V variants + soul cadences
Core elements	Piano/organ, choir or stacked BGVs, live drums or realistic kits, bass guitar, tambourine
Mix vibe	Warm, wide vocals, natural rooms, dynamic (not over-squashed)

Gospel production essentials

- Hammond organ (B3) with Leslie simulation is iconic; piano comps with rhythmic stabs.
- Chord vocabulary includes walk-ups, passing diminished chords, and big dominant chains.
- Choir arrangement: SATB thinking even with stacked solo singers — write parts that harmonize the melody.
- Tambourine on offbeats/upbeats in celebratory sections.
- Dynamic form: quiet testimony → building → full praise peak.

Neo-soul notes

Imperfect timing as aesthetic, Rhodes-centered harmony, muffled drums, intimate vocals, jazz-informed chords, and arrangements that feel like a band in a small room. Resist over-quantizing. Saturation and gentle compression glue the band bus.

12. Funk & Disco

The almighty pocket: syncopation, four-on-the-floor variants, bass as lead

Typical BPM	Funk: 90–115 Disco: 110–130 (classic ~118–124)
Feel	16th-note syncopation; guitar chicken scratch; interlocking parts
Keys	Dominant 7, Mixolydian vamps, minor funk vamps, disco major joy
Core elements	Bass guitar heroics, tight drums, rhythm guitar, horns, strings (disco), percussion
Mix vibe	Punchy, danceable, clear midrange rhythm, strong mono kick/bass

Funk drum & bass

Funk drums emphasize the “one” (James Brown doctrine) while snare and hats create conversation. Ghost notes are mandatory. Bass is melodic and rhythmic — ghost notes, slides, 16th syncopations. Guitar plays muted 16ths (wah optional). Horns hit stabs on offbeats. Arrange as interlocking puzzle pieces; each part leaves space for others (negative space is funk).

Disco blueprint

- Four-on-the-floor kick with open hat on offbeats (classic).
- Octave bass lines (root–octave patterns) very common.
- Lush strings, rhythm guitars, piano four-to-the-floor comps or offbeat comps.
- Build for the dancefloor: long intros, percussion breaks, filter fun.
- Modern nu-disco adds sidechain pumping and cleaner digital polish.

Producer tip: Record or program guitar and bass with slight timing push/pull — perfect quantize kills disco sweat.

PART III — Electronic Dance Music

EDM umbrella genres prioritize the club/festival body response: kick energy, hypnotic repetition, DJ-friendly arrangement, and sound design as the “lead singer.” Subgenres differ wildly in tempo, drum patterns, bass design, and harmonic density. Always test on a system with real sub if you produce for clubs.

13. House (Deep, Tech, Progressive, Future)

Four-on-the-floor soul of the dancefloor

Typical BPM	118–130 (classic house ~120–125; tech house often 124–128)
Feel	Four-on-the-floor kick; offbeat open hats; groovy basslines
Keys	Minor house common; deep house jazzier; future house brighter pop harmony
Core elements	Kick, clap/snare on 2/4, hats, bass, chords/stabs, vocal chops or full vocals
Mix vibe	Club-ready low end, wide percussion, clear mid hooks

Universal house drum grid

- Kick on every quarter note (1, 2, 3, 4).
- Clap/snare on 2 and 4.
- Closed hats 8th or 16th; open hat on offbeats (the “and” of each beat) is classic.
- Percussion layers (shakers, congas, bongos, rim) create swing and identity.
- Groove templates: slight swing on 16ths for classic house feel.

Substyle cheat sheet

- **Deep house:** warmer chords (7/9), Rhodes/pads, soulful vocals, smoother bass, lush but not harsh.
- **Tech house:** minimal melodic content, hypnotic percussion, stripped bass, DJ tool structures.
- **Progressive house:** longer builds, emotional breakdowns, bigger chord stacks, festival-friendly.
- **Future house:** heavy sidechain, rubbery bass, bright plucks, pop structures, modern sheen.
- **Afro house:** organic percussion, log drums, tribal rhythms, spiritual/atmospheric pads.

Bass & sound design

Bass often plays syncopated patterns against the kick. Sidechain compression (or volume ducking) to the kick is nearly mandatory in modern house. Chords: short stabs or long filtered pads. Vocal chops as instruments are a house staple — pitch them musically, rhythmically gate them, reverb/delay for width.

Arrangement for DJs

- 16–32 bar intro (percussion + kick) for mixing in.
- Groove establish → add bass → add hook → breakdown → build → drop (full elements).
- Mid-song break with filter automation.
- 16–32 bar outro for mixing out.

Producer tip: Mark phrase lengths in 8/16/32 bars. DJs and dancers feel these blocks unconsciously.

14. Techno

Hypnosis, functional design, industrial beauty, relentless pulse

Typical BPM	125–140 (peak-time often 130–135; slower deep techno exists)
Feel	Four-on-the-floor; machine precision; evolving textures over long forms
Keys	Often minor/modal; sometimes atonal/textural rather than chord-driven
Core elements	Powerful kick, hi-hats, metallic percussion, drones, acid lines, sparse motifs
Mix vibe	Mono-compatible kick, controlled mids, club translation over earbuds alone

Philosophy

Techno (Detroit roots; Berlin evolution) is less about hooks-per-minute and more about altered state through repetition and gradual change. Production quality of the kick and the interest of the evolving layers matter more than chord complexity.

How to build a techno track

- Design a kick that can carry 6+ minutes (layer sub + punch + click carefully).
- Add a complementary bass pulse or offbeat bass.
- Introduce metallic hats/rides; automate filters slowly.
- Use one memorable motif (stab, acid 303-style line, vocal fragment) sparingly.
- Arrangement: long arcs, subtractive changes, DJ-friendly structure.
- Sound design: industrial samples, FM metallic tones, noise beds, modular-style modulation.

Producer tip: Automate one parameter per long section (filter cutoff, reverb send, delay feedback) — techno is the art of patient change.

15. Trance & Progressive Trance

Emotional supersaws, tension/release, uplifting journeys

Typical BPM	130–145 (uplifting often ~138; progressive can be lower)
Feel	Four-on-the-floor; rolling bass; big builds and euphoric releases
Keys	Minor for emotion; major lifts; dramatic chord progressions
Core elements	Supersaw leads, arps, pads, gated/chopped chords, snare rolls, uplifting leads
Mix vibe	Wide stereo leads, clean sub, shiny highs without ear fatigue

Sound design staples

- Supersaw: multiple detuned saws, unison, slight stereo spread, filter envelope for pluck/lead shapes.
- Arpeggiators locked to tempo; rhythmic gates on pads/chords.
- Snare rolls: increasing density into downbeat; sometimes pitch risers with them.
- Breakdown: strip drums, emotional melody/chords, then full rebuild into drop.
- Bass: rolling offbeat or on-beat patterns supporting kick; sidechain heavily for pumping if style fits.

Writing emotional progressions

Use longer chord durations in breakdowns, suspend resolutions, and introduce the main lead only when earned. Counter-melodies in fifths/thirds stack for “big” feeling. Avoid overcrowding the lead’s midrange.

16. Drum & Bass / Jungle

Amen history, 170 BPM energy, sub bass science, break science

Typical BPM	170–178 (liquid can sit ~170; neurofunk similar range)
Feel	Fast breakbeats or programmed breaks; half-time bass feel often
Keys	Minor common; liquid more harmonic; neuro more sound-design lead
Core elements	Breaks/reprogrammed drums, sub bass, reese bass, pads (liquid), sound design (neuro)
Mix vibe	Sub clarity, mid bass aggression (neuro), airy tops, DJ-friendly drops

Breakbeat craft

Historically, jungle/DnB sliced funk breaks (Amen break famously). Modern production: use high-quality break samples or synthesize with one-shots. Slice by transient, rearrange, layer with acoustic kick/snare for weight. Ghosting and edits create the “rolling” feel. Parallel compression for glue and aggression.

Bass categories

- **Sub bass:** clean sine/triangle mono fundamental — the club floor mover.
- **Reese:** detuned saws with movement (LFOs, phasing) — mid-bass body.
- **Neuro bass:** complex FM/wavetable/modulation chains, multiband distortion, automation as performance.
- Relationship: sub carries weight; mid bass carries character. Split bands and process separately.

Substyles

- **Liquid:** musical chords, vocals, smoother drums, emotional pads.
- **Jump-up:** bouncy bass phrases, energetic, simpler hooks.
- **Neurofunk:** dark, technical sound design, precise drums, sci-fi atmospheres.
- **Jungle revival:** more break-centric, ragga samples, chaotic energy.

Producer tip: At 174 BPM, a 1-bar loop flies by — arrange in 8/16 bar phrases and use automation to avoid monotony.

17. Dubstep & Riddim

Wobbles, drops, half-time weight, sound design as the star

Typical BPM	138–150 with half-time feel (snare on 3)
Feel	Half-time groove; silence and space as weapons; massive drop contrast
Keys	Minor/dark; often riff-based rather than lush progressions
Core elements	Heavy kick/snare, growls/wobbles, reese, vocal chops, FX
Mix vibe	Huge perceived loudness on drop; clean sub; midrange aggression controlled

Drop writing

Dubstep is about contrast: sparse or atmospheric intros/verses explode into bass-weight drops. Design 2–4 unique bass patches and sequence them as call-and-response. LFO rates on filters/wavetable positions synced to tempo create wobbles (1/4, 1/8, 1/16 rates). Riddim emphasizes repetitive hypnotic bass motifs and hard-hitting minimal drums.

Practical sound design tips

- Layer: sub (sine) + mid growl (distorted) + top click/noise for definition.
- Multiband distortion: distort mids hard, keep sub clean.
- Resample bass phrases to audio for further chopping and glitching.
- Transitions: silence, reverse bass, snare builds, vocal “hey” risers.

Producer tip: *If the drop feels weak, the problem is often arrangement contrast or mid-bass clarity — not “needing more plugins.”*

18. UK Garage, 2-Step & Grime

Shuffled drums, skippy swing, MC space, UK street futurism

Typical BPM	UKG/2-step: ~128–138 Grime: ~135–140
Feel	Skipped kicks, syncopated snares/claps, swung hats — not plain four-on-floor
Keys	Minor common; garage can be soulful major/minor; grime colder
Core elements	Shuffling drums, deep bass, pitched vocals (garage), sparse cold instrumentals (grime)
Mix vibe	Bouncy, clear mid bass, vocal/MC intelligibility

2-step garage drums

Remove some kicks from a four-on-the-floor pattern so the kick “skips.” Syncopate snares/claps. Swing 16ths. Add shakers and organic percussion. Bass is deep and melodic; chord stabs and pitched vocal chops (time-stretched R&B samples historically) define classic UKG. Modern revival garage blends pop vocals with classic shuffle.

Grime instrumentals

Grime instrumentals (“riddims”) leave huge space for MCs. Cold synths, simple dark loops, square/pulse leads, sparse drums with distinctive bounce, and bold silence. Don’t overfill — the vocal is the lead instrument. Influence from jungle/garage DNA remains in the energy.

19. Hardstyle / Hard Dance

Reverse bass, screeches, hard kicks, euphoric or raw extremes

Typical BPM	150–160 (raw harder can push higher)
Feel	Driving kicks, energetic half-time or full-on patterns depending on era/substyle
Keys	Minor anthems; dramatic leads
Core elements	Distorted kick, reverse bass, lead screeches, climax structure, vocal chants
Mix vibe	Kick is king; mid lead clarity; extreme energy without pure harshness

Kick & reverse bass

Hardstyle kicks are designed, not merely sampled: long kick bodies, distortion, pitch envelopes, and careful clipping. Reverse bass plays offbeat or patterned notes ducking around the kick. Leads can be euphoric (melodic hardstyle) or raw/aggressive (screech-heavy). Arrangement builds to multiple climaxes common in festival hard dance.

20. Ambient, Downtempo & IDM

Space, texture, anti-drop aesthetics, listening music

Typical BPM	Ambient: free/none or 60–100 Downtempo: 70–100 IDM: variable
Feel	Non-dance or abstract pulse; atmosphere over club function
Keys	Modal, sparse, experimental harmony; drones
Core elements	Pads, field recordings, granular textures, gentle or glitchy percussion
Mix vibe	Dynamic range preserved; wide stereo; detail in quiet

Techniques

- Long reverb tails and convolution spaces (halls, churches, found spaces).
- Granular synthesis on vocals/instruments for clouds.
- Field recordings as beds (rain, rooms, cities) — EQ and place carefully.
- IDM: complex non-repeating drum programming, glitch edits, odd structures.
- Avoid over-limiting; silence and quiet are part of the composition.

Producer tip: Ambient arrangement is sculpting attention over time — introduce one new element every 30–60 seconds.

PART IV — Pop & Mainstream

Pop production is the art of clarity: memorable toplines, efficient arrangements, and mixes that translate everywhere. Pop absorbs other genres continuously — trap drums under pop choruses, house drops in radio edits, guitar bands with electronic programming. The constant is the song.

21. Contemporary Pop

Hooks, contrast, vocal production, cross-genre borrowing

Typical BPM	90–130 depending on era trend; ballads slower; dance-pop higher
Feel	Clean quantized or lightly human; strong downbeats; chorus lift
Keys	Accessible progressions (I–V–vi–IV family and variants); key changes rare but effective
Core elements	Lead vocal, stacked BGVs, tight drums, bass, hook motif (synth/guitar)
Mix vibe	Vocal #1, competitive loudness, wide chorus, mono-compatible core

The pop arrangement contract

- Intro: short (4–8 bars) — get to vocal/hook fast for streaming.
- Verse: lower energy, storytelling, fewer layers.
- Pre-chorus: tension — rising melody, snare roll, filter open, chord lift.
- Chorus: highest energy, fullest stack, simplest/most memorable lyric-melody.
- Verse 2: slight variation (new counter-melody or drum fill pattern).
- Bridge: contrast (half-time, new chords, stripped or climactic).
- Final chorus: extra layer (harmony, ad-libs, key lift optional).

Vocal production (the real pop instrument)

- Comping: select best syllables from multiple takes.
- Tuning: transparent for most pop; stylistic hard tune when intentional.
- Timing: align doubles; keep lead human enough.
- Stacks: doubles, triples on chorus; octaves; harmonies on key words.
- FX: slap delay, 1/4 or 1/8 delay throws, short plates, creative transitions (reverse vocal).
- De-ess and control sibilance before brightening.

Writing with production in mind

Leave space in the beat for the chorus lyric rhythm. Use call-and-response between synth hook and vocal. Mute instruments under important words. Automate interest so verse 2 never feels identical to verse 1.

Producer tip: *If the chorus doesn't feel bigger, remove verse elements rather than only adding chorus elements — contrast is relative.*

22. K-Pop Production Language

Maximal arrangement, section variety, hybrid genre medleys inside one song

Typical BPM	Wide range; songs often change feel mid-track
Feel	Highly produced, tight timing, dramatic switches
Keys	Pop-accessible with unexpected modulations and EDM lifts
Core elements	Multiple hooks, rap sections, dance breaks, orchestral/EDM/band hybrids
Mix vibe	Ultra polished, wide, vocal group clarity, bright competitive top

What to study

K-pop tracks frequently contain verse styles that differ from pre-chorus and drop into EDM or hip-hop for dance breaks. Produce “sections as mini-genres” under one master aesthetic (shared vocal chain, consistent drum sample family or deliberate switches). Group vocals and choreography-ready drops matter. Sound design is glossy; transitions are cinematic.

23. Hyperpop & PC Music Influences

Maximal brightness, exaggerated tuning, internet maximalism

Typical BPM	High energy often 140+; or nightcore-like sped feels; also glitchy midtempo
Feel	Over-quantized or chaotically edited; cartoon dynamics
Keys	Bright major or emotional minor with extreme sound design
Core elements	Hard-tuned vocals, metallic/synth leads, compressed everything, glitch edits, ironic clichés
Mix vibe	Loud, bright, saturated, intentionally “too much”

Techniques

- Extreme autotune/formant shifts as aesthetic.
- Sidechain everything; pump as a style.
- Bitcrush, sample-rate reduction, aggressive clipping.
- Pop structure with sudden genre cuts and meme-like sound references.
- Embrace digital artifacts instead of hiding them.

24. Synthwave / Retrowave / Outrun

1980s fantasy: analog aesthetics, neon nostalgia, driving arps

Typical BPM	80–120 midtempo common; outrun driving tracks often ~100–118
Feel	Steady electronic groove; gated snares; nostalgic space
Keys	Minor for night-drive mood; major for uplifting retro pop
Core elements	Analog-style bass, saw leads, FM bells, gated reverb snare, arpeggios, chrome pads
Mix vibe	Warm yet shiny; tape/chorus character; cinematic width

Palette & drums

Emulate 80s drum machines (LINN, DMX, 808/909 aesthetic) with gated reverb on snares. Analog bass (Juno/Jupiter-style) playing eighths or driving patterns. Brass patches, digital FM bells (DX7 lore), and large halls. Melodies are memorable and slightly heroic. Darksynth leans more aggressive/distorted; outrun emphasizes driving motion and night aesthetics.

Producer tip: Reference film scores of the 80s and modern synthwave leaders; the genre is as visual as it is musical.

PART V — Rock, Alternative & Metal

25. Rock & Indie Rock

Guitars as narrative, band dynamics, human performance

Typical BPM	100–160 depending on substyle; indie often midtempo
Feel	Live push/pull; backbeat snare; riff or chord-driven
Keys	Power chord rock; indie more diatonic/alternative harmony
Core elements	Electric guitars, bass guitar, acoustic/live drums, vocals
Mix vibe	Guitar/vocal balance war; natural drums or modern punch; mono-compatible kick/snare/bass

Tracking mindset

Even in the DAW, rock benefits from performance. Layer rhythm guitars L/R (double tracking). DI + amp sim or real amp. Bass DI + amp blend. Drums: either live multi-mic or high-quality hybrid programmed kits with humanization. Focus on the riff and the chorus lift (guitar energy + vocal hooks).

Indie specifics

Texture over virtuosity: chorus/vibed guitars, lo-fi room sounds, intimate vocals, less perfect tuning. Arrangement may be deliberately sparse. Reverb choices define era (spring, plate, hall).

26. Punk & Post-Punk

Speed, attitude, minimalism, angular grooves

Typical BPM	Punk: 160–220 energy Post-punk: often midtempo, danceable darkness
Feel	Driving eighths; urgency; post-punk bass-led grooves
Keys	Simple progressions; modal post-punk vamps
Core elements	Distorted guitars, prominent bass, raw drums, urgent vocals
Mix vibe	Rawer than pop; midrange aggression; don't over-polish unless pop-punk

Production notes

Punk: capture energy — faster songs, power chords, gang vocals, minimal overdubs. Pop-punk polishes this with tighter tuning and bigger choruses. Post-punk: melodic basslines as lead, cleaner/angular guitars, chorus/delay, danceable drum patterns, darker atmospheres. Leave imperfections that signal live urgency.

27. Metal (Modern & Substyles Overview)

Precision, weight, guitar tone science, extreme dynamics

Typical BPM	Wide: 60 doom to 220+ extreme; modern metalcore often dual feels
Feel	Palm-muted chugs, double kick, breakdown half-time, blast beats (extreme)
Keys	Minor, Phrygian, harmonic minor; djent often low-tuned riff modality
Core elements	High-gain guitars, tight DI bass, triggered/hybrid drums, aggressive vocals
Mix vibe	Guitar clarity with heavy low end; kick/guitar carve; vocal intelligibility in chaos

Guitar production

- Tuning: drop tunings and 7/8-string extended range common in modern styles.
- DI recording + amp sims (or reamp) for editability.
- Tight editing of chugs to grid for modern metal; more human for classic/thrash feels.
- Quad-track rhythms (double L/R) carefully phase-aligned.
- Lead tones: higher gain mid-focused, delay/verb for solos.

Drums & low end

Kick and guitar fight for 100–200 Hz — carve with EQ. Sample reinforcement on kick/snare is standard in modern metal. Bass often follows guitar rhythm with high-mids for click on small speakers plus sub weight. Breakdowns: half-time, open space, maximum impact hits.

Substyle pointers

- **Thrash:** speed, palm mutes, aggressive picks, less low-tuned than djent.
- **Death/black:** extreme vocals, blasts, darker production philosophies differ (raw vs modern polish).
- **Metalcore/djent:** polyrhythms, low chugs, electronic textures sometimes, huge choruses in metalcore.
- **Doom:** slow, massive sustained weight, darker spaces.

PART VI — Global, Roots & Acoustic Traditions

28. Jazz (for Producers)

Improvisation space, swing, acoustic truth, sophisticated harmony

Typical BPM	Ballad 60–80 medium swing 100–140 uptempo higher
Feel	Swing eighths; ride cymbal language; interactive dynamics
Keys	ii–V–I world; extended/altered dominants; modal jazz vamps
Core elements	Ride/hats, acoustic bass, piano/comping, horns/solos, brushes possible
Mix vibe	Natural dynamics, realistic space, avoid over-compression

Producer approach

If sampling jazz for hip-hop, respect timing/feel of original. If producing jazz artists: capture great performances with good rooms/mics; light editing; preserve dynamics. Comping instruments leave space for soloists. Walking bass outlines harmony. Drummer's ride pattern defines swing. For jazz-influenced beatmaking (lo-fi/neo-soul), use 7th/9th chords, brush kits, and imperfect loops.

29. Country & Americana

Story-first songwriting, twang vocabulary, modern pop hybrids

Typical BPM	70–140; ballads to train-beat uptempos
Feel	Straight or gentle swing; train beats; two-step feels
Keys	Major common; accessible progressions; modal folk flavors
Core elements	Acoustic guitar, electric twang, pedal steel, fiddle, tight vocals, organic drums
Mix vibe	Vocal story clarity; polished modern country can be pop-loud

Instruments that signal country

- Acoustic guitar strums as bed.
- Telecaster-style twang leads and chicken pickin’.
- Pedal steel or lap steel slides for emotion.
- Fiddle hooks and fills.
- Harmonies in thirds; gang/stack vocals on choruses.
- Modern country: 808s and trap hats sometimes appear under banjo/acoustic — hybrid carefully.

Song form

Story verses, memorable choruses, optional bridge, instrumental breaks for solos. Lyrics matter more than sound design fireworks. Production serves the narrative and the singer’s character.

30. Reggae, Dancehall & Dub

Offbeat skank, heavy bass culture, space as rhythm

Typical BPM	Reggae: ~70–90 (or double-time feel) Dancehall: ~90–110+ Dub remix culture
Feel	One-drop/rockers/steppers drum variants; guitar/keyboard offbeats
Keys	Major & minor; modal vamps common
Core elements	Bass as lead, skank guitar/keys, rimshots, deep space FX (dub)
Mix vibe	Bass-forward, spacious, hypnotic

Core patterns

- **Skank:** guitar/keys on offbeats (the “and” of each beat).
- **One-drop:** emphasis where kick/snare land together on beat 3 feel (classic reggae variants).
- Basslines are melodic, deep, and repetitive — the song’s spine.
- Dancehall: digital rhythms, dembow-related patterns in some eras, vocal toasting/rigging energy.
- Dub: remix philosophy — drop vocals, slam delays/reverbs, filter sweeps, drum/bass focus, FX as performance.

Producer tip: In dub, automate sends live-style; print performances of the mixer as part of composition.

31. Latin: Reggaeton, Salsa, Bachata, Latin Trap

Dembow engine, clave awareness, romantic and club fire

Typical BPM	Reggaeton: ~85–100 Salsa: ~180–240 pulse feels Bachata: ~120–140 Latin trap: trap BPMs
Feel	Dembow for reggaeton; clave for Afro-Cuban; guitar-led bachata romance
Keys	Minor common in reggaeton/trap; salsa rich harmony; bachata romantic major/minor
Core elements	Dembow drums, dembow-aligned bass, dembow vocal flow; or live Latin percussion sections
Mix vibe	Vocal + rhythm clarity; club sub for urban Latin

Reggaeton production

The dembow rhythm is the heartbeat — a specific kick/snare relationship derived from dancehall/reggae lineage and popularized globally. Program authentic dembow first, then melody. Modern reggaeton blends with pop and EDM: bright synths, guitars, dembow variations, and hooky choruses. 808s common. Vocal is rhythmic and central; autotune aesthetic varies by artist.

Salsa & Afro-Cuban awareness

Clave (son or rumba) organizes the ensemble. Piano montunos, tumbao bass, congas/timbales/bongos, brass sections. If producing authentic salsa, study clave alignment — parts that “cross” the clave feel wrong to trained dancers/musicians. Hybrid Latin pop may simplify but still references these rhythms.

Bachata

Guitar guira patterns, romantic vocals, syncopated guitar arpeggios, simple drums/bongo, bass outlining harmony. Modern bachata can be denser and more pop-electronic.

Latin trap

Trap drum language + Spanish-language flows + reggaeton/Latin melodic flavor. Darker 808s, hi-hat rolls, and urban atmospheres with Latin percussion ornaments.

32. Afrobeats, Amapiano & African Pop

Log drums, joyful groove, percussion abundance, global fusion

Typical BPM	Afrobeats: ~95–115 Amapiano: ~110–115 common
Feel	Syncopated, dancing, percussion-forward; amapiano midtempo bounce
Keys	Major & minor; catchy loop harmony; soulful progressions
Core elements	Percussion layers, log drum (amapiano), bass, guitars, vocal hooks, shakers
Mix vibe	Groove clarity, warm lows, bright percussion without harshness

Afrobeats

Blend of West African pop sensibilities with Caribbean/Western influences. Drums are syncopated and layered: kicks not always four-on-floor, snare/clap patterns bounce, and percussion (shakers, congas, sticks) creates continuous motion. Guitars and synths play catchy ostinatos. Vocals are melodic and central. Global afrobeats collaborations often fuse with dancehall, R&B, and pop.

Amapiano

South African genre known for log drum bass melodies, wide lush chords/pads, midtempo groove, shakers, and atmospheric jazz/soul influence. The log drum acts as both bass and melodic percussion — program it musically with space. Soft but present kick; spacious mixes; hypnotic repetition with evolving percussion.

Producer tip: Don't overcrowd the log drum's mid-low range with competing 808s — pick a low-end hero.

33. Classical / Cinematic / Orchestral Hybrid

Orchestration, themes, hybrid trailer music, DAW mockups

Typical BPM	Flexible; dictated by scene/emotion; trailers often half-time epic pulses
Feel	Rubato possible; or rigid epic pulses in modern trailer music
Keys	Functional harmony, modes, clusters, extended contemporary techniques
Core elements	Strings, brass, woodwinds, percussion, choir, hybrid synths/drums
Mix vibe	Wide stage, depth layers (close/far), dynamic range (except trailers which are loud)

Mockup production

Use quality orchestral libraries; articulate (legato, staccato, spiccato, pizz). Write with real ranges and breathing in mind. Layer synths under orchestra for modern hybrid scores. Percussion: taikos, hybrid impacts, ticks for tension. Theme development: introduce motif, vary instrumentation/harmony/rhythm. For pure classical production (recording musicians): conductor/producer collaboration, room choice, mic trees.

Trailer music formula (simplified)

- Tick/clock percussion build
- Low brass/braam hits
- Choir swells
- Melody on strings/brass
- Biggest hit near end (the “trailer moment”)
- Silence and impacts as punctuation

PART VII — Niche, Hybrid & Internet-Era Genres

34. Lo-fi Hip-Hop

Study beats, dusty comfort, imperfect beauty

Typical BPM	70–95
Feel	Swung, lazy pocket, vinyl texture
Keys	Jazz/soul 7th chords; minor and major seventh loops
Core elements	Chopped jazz samples or original keys, soft drums, vinyl crackle, soft bass
Mix vibe	Band-limited, warm, not loudness-war; gentle compression

Recipe

- Chord loop with maj7/m7/9 colors; rhodes/piano.
- Drums with soft kick, snappy but gentle snare, swung hats; sidechain lightly to kick optional.
- Pitch drums slightly uniquely; add wow/flutter.
- Vinyl noise bed low in mix.
- Filter highs for “radio/memory” aesthetic; saturation.
- Arrangement: long loopable forms for streaming/playlists; subtle variations every 8–16 bars.

Producer tip: *The best lo-fi still has good composition — don’t use “lo-fi” as an excuse for unmusical loops only.*

35. Phonk & Drift Phonk

Cowbells, Memphis DNA, distorted 808s, car culture energy

Typical BPM	Phonk often ~130–160 half-time feels; drift phonk energetic mid-high
Feel	Aggressive bounce; cowbell ostinatos; distorted low end
Keys	Dark minor; sampled vocal phrases from Memphis rap aesthetics (cleared/royalty-free)
Core elements	Cowbell, hard 808, distorted samples, drift-ready energy
Mix vibe	Loud, distorted, bass-heavy, intentionally gritty

Production notes

Phonk draws from 90s Memphis rap aesthetics filtered through modern internet culture. Drift phonk emphasizes cowbell melodies, distorted 808s, and high-energy edits suited to car/drift video culture. Use strong repetitive motifs, heavy saturation, and confident simplicity. Respect sample legality.

36. Cloud Rap & Emo Rap Textures

Airy atmospheres, emotional vocals, ethereal traps

Typical BPM	Trap-adjacent ranges; often spacious half-time
Feel	Floaty, less hard-quantized aggression; dreamy
Keys	Emotional minor; ambient harmony
Core elements	Airy pads, reverb-drenched melodies, soft or hazy drums, intimate/emo vocals
Mix vibe	Wide, wet, vocal emotional clarity, soft transients possible

How to get the texture

Long reverb on melodic elements, high-cut drums for haze, pitched vocal chops as pads, less dense hat programming than hard trap, and lyrics/melody-forward emotion. Emo rap hybrids may add guitars and live-feeling rock energy under trap drums.

37. Experimental / Genre-Bending Strategy

How to invent fusions without random mess

Typical BPM	Whatever serves the idea
Feel	Defined by your hybrid contract
Keys	Free
Core elements	One clear “center of gravity” + borrowed ornaments
Mix vibe	Consistency of space and vocal/lead treatment glues hybrids

A method that works

1. Choose a primary genre contract (e.g., “this is a house track”).
2. Borrow ONE foreign element (e.g., trap hats, metal guitar, salsa piano).
3. Keep drums or bass in the primary genre so the body still recognizes the home style.
4. Unify with consistent mix bus processing and a recurring motif.
5. Name the experiment after the feeling, not after every influence.

Producer tip: Hybrids fail when every element is from a different genre at once. Hierarchy beats collage.

PART VIII — Reference Systems

38. BPM / Key / Drum Map Quick Reference

Use this as a starting grid, not a prison. Many hits sit outside these ranges. When in doubt, match the reference track's tempo map and drum density first.

Genre	BPM	Drum identity	Bass identity
Boom bap	85–98	Swing, snare 2&4	Sampled/electric simple
Trap	130–150 HT	Snare on 3, hat rolls	Sliding 808
Drill	138–146	Stutter hats, sharp snare	Slide 808 phrases
R&B	60–115	Pocket, ghosts	Melodic electric/808
House	120–128	4x4 kick, offbeat OH	Syncopated + sidechain
Techno	130–135	4x4 machine	Pulse/offbeat
Trance	132–140	4x4 + snare builds	Rolling bass
DnB	170–178	Breaks / fast edits	Sub + reese/neuro
Dubstep	140 HT	Half-time knock	Wobble/growl+sub
Pop	90–130	Clean, chorus lift	Supportive, clear
Reggaeton	85–100	Dembow	Dembow-aligned
Afrobeats	95–115	Syncopated layers	Groovy mid/sub
Amapiano	110–115	Soft kick + shakers	Log drum melody
Reggae	70–90	One-drop variants	Deep melodic bass
Metal	wide	Double kick / chug sync	Follow guitars
Synthwave	100–118	Gated snare, 80s kit	Analog eighths
Lo-fi	70–95	Soft swung kit	Warm simple sub
Disco	118–124	4x4 + offbeat hats	Octave basslines

HT = half-time feel. For keys: minor dominates darker urban/electronic styles; major still powers country, gospel lifts, disco joy, and many pop choruses. Always confirm with a reference track in your exact substyle.

39. Plugin & Stock-Tool Cookbook

Universal stock-tool strategies (any DAW)

- EQ: high-pass junk; cut mud 200–400 Hz; presence 2–5 kHz for vocals; air 10–12 kHz sparingly.
- Compressor: 2:1–4:1 for vocals; faster for control, slower for transparency; parallel for punch.
- Saturator/clipper: harmonics for small speakers; clip drum bus carefully.
- Sidechain: kick triggers bus duck on bass/pads (house/EDM/pop).
- Stereo imager: widen only above ~150–200 Hz; keep sub mono.
- Delay: tempo sync 1/8, 1/4, dotted; high-pass/low-pass the wet signal.
- Reverb: short rooms for drums; longer halls for pads; pre-delay to keep vocals clear.

Genre-oriented tool choices (examples, not endorsements)

- Trap/hip-hop: good 808 (or Serum/Phase Plant/3xOSC design), tuner, vocal chain, drum sampler.
- EDM: wavetable synth, strong limiter, transient shaper, stereo tools, LFO modulators.

- Rock/metal: amp sims, IR cabs, drum sample replacer/reinforcement, tight editing tools.
- Orchestral: large libraries + expression/mod wheel automation + reverb halls.
- Jazz/soul: good piano/Rhodes, tape, gentle buses, realistic drum libraries.

Producer tip: *Your ears and arrangement beat your plugin count. One well-chosen synth and excellent samples outperform fifty unused presets.*

40. Finishing Checklist (Any Genre)

- Does the track announce its genre (or hybrid intent) within 15 seconds?
- Is there a clear focal point in every section (vocal, bass riff, lead, or drums)?
- Kick–bass relationship clean on club system / car / phone?
- Hooks memorable without the rest of the arrangement?
- Arrangement contrast: verse vs chorus OR break vs drop actually different?
- Automation rides: energy moves, not static loops for 3 minutes?
- Transitions designed (not abrupt accidental cuts unless aesthetic)?
- Vocal intelligibility (if present) on small speakers?
- Mono compatibility checked?
- Referenced against 2 commercial tracks at matched loudness?
- Exported with correct sample rate/bit depth; true peak headroom for streaming?
- Metadata, version notes, and dry/wet vocal stems archived for future edits?

Glossary (Selected)

808: Originally TR-808 drum machine; now usually means long tuned bass/kick sine used in hip-hop/trap.

Sidechain: Using one signal (often kick) to control compression/volume of another (often bass).

Reese: Detuned, moving bass sound common in DnB.

Supersaw: Many detuned saw oscillators stacked for huge trance/EDM leads.

Dembow: Foundational rhythmic pattern in reggaeton.

One-drop: Reggae drum feel emphasizing particular beats / de-emphasizing the one in classic forms.

Clave: Guiding rhythmic key pattern in Afro-Cuban music.

Half-time: Snare placement that makes a fast BPM feel half as fast (common in trap/dubstep).

Ghost note: Soft drum hit that creates groove between main accents.

Parallel compression: Blend heavily compressed signal under dry for punch without killing dynamics.

Headroom: Space before 0 dBFS; needed for processing and mastering.

Topline: Main vocal melody/lyric line in pop writing sessions.

Break / breakbeat: Drum loop isolated from older funk records; foundational to jungle/hip-hop history.

Sound selection: Choosing the right sample/preset before processing — often 80% of the result.

Closing Notes

Genre is a shared language between maker and listener. Learn the language fluently enough that you can speak it without an accent — then develop your own dialect. The producers who stand out are not those who ignore genre, nor those who only copy surface presets, but those who understand the deep contracts (groove, space, bass behavior, vocal role, arrangement energy) and then make one bold personal choice inside that frame.

Practice plan: pick one genre per week. Finish two short tracks (60–90 seconds is fine) using only that genre's drum identity and bass identity. Reference constantly. On week four, hybrid two of them using the hierarchy method in Chapter 37. In three months you will hear music differently — as systems of decisions rather than magic you either have or don't.

This handbook is intentionally practical and broad. Each genre contains decades of history and regional micro-styles that reward deeper study: listen widely, credit sources, clear samples when releasing commercially, and collaborate with musicians who live inside traditions you are still learning.

End of Guide — Now open your DAW and make the first ugly loop. Finish it. Then make another.

Music Producer's Complete Genre Guide • Desktop Reference Edition